

The God of Small THINGS

Arzee's dreams are expansive, his problems gigantic and his universe full of fears

| By Omair Ahmad |



ARZEE THE DWARF

by CHANDRAHAS

CHOUDHURY

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About a quarter of the way through *Arzee the Dwarf*, one of the characters, Dashrath—the wise taxi driver, who supplies dialogues for Bhojpuri movies and loves his metaphors—asks, “Do we live the life given to us, or do we really live a kind of dream life... Isn't our real life really a life of the imagination?” It is not an original thought, but the success of Chandras Choudhury's debut novel lies in how movingly he manages to bring out this little truth through the life of the eponymous Arzee the dwarf.

A projectionist at a dilapidated theatre called the Noor, Arzee is in love with his profession, with the Babur (which is how they mis-pronounce Bauer, the German film projector) and his one dream is to become the head projectionist when the ageing Pherozebbhai retires. The story begins with Arzee sitting around a game of cards with his friends, and the knowledge that Pherozebbhai's retirement around the corner gnawing in his belly. Caught with a bad set of cards, he throws a tantrum, but also divulges this key hope to his friends, who all congratulate him. One of them, Shinde, even manages to extract a fifty-rupee loan

that Arzee gives with only the greatest difficulty, only to have Shinde hand the note right back and start laughing. “I was just checking if good fortune had done anything to change our miser friend... but once a tightfist, always a tightfist.”

Choudhury excels at creating these immediately believable characters, who taunt, guide, and console Arzee throughout the book. Principally though, we live the action through the thoughts of Arzee himself, who is always getting ahead of himself, planning on what he will buy once he has his raise, how he will behave with his wife, what he will tell his mother—who is always Mother with a capital ‘M’—when everything comes crashing down as reality intrudes. Arzee wails in despair, “I've dreamt, loved, hoped and lived in imagined worlds, and later I've been miserable... I've been doubly deceived in life—deceived by life, without a doubt, and then deceived by my own illusions.”

As his dreams recede, the fears rise, and suddenly all that is dark looms up out of Arzee's life. There is the ominous Deepak from the unnamed syndicate, searching after Arzee for the gambling debts that Arzee owes. There is the ‘soft tyranny’ of his mother's hopes and fears, and lingering somewhere in the back, the deeply hurtful memory of a love affair that went unexpectedly sour. Throughout it all Arzee keeps talking, telling stories to himself, “He was his own concert and his own audience,” or to anybody who will listen to him, even if they only listen in exasperation—as Deepak does. The conversation, principally with himself but also with the universe, is how Arzee marks out his territory, and in that territory he is not—however short he may be in height—a dwarf. He is, like many of us, a small person dealing with problems that we imagine are gigantic but which, with friends and a little luck, recede to a size we can manage.

The language is a bit choppy. There is a cleavage that “hummed unsettlingly at the periphery of Arzee's vision”, overlong sentences and paragraphs, as well as a few hundred exclamation marks. This might have been Choudhury's intent to bring out Arzee's choppy thoughts, but is at times a distraction from a very compelling story. The ending is a little brighter than believable, but Arzee is compelling enough a character that I, for one, was happy for him. ■

SAURABH SINGH

